

Aleena Anto. Final Asian Games entries remain subject to RFI's selection process and benchmark evaluation.

Priya, from Moirang in Manipur's Bishnupur district, competed at the Hangzhou Asian Games while violence back home was tearing through the state. She finished fifth in both the women's four and women's eight, but the results alone do not explain what she carried into that regatta.

Former Asian Games rower and current India women's team coach Narangam Lakshmi Devi has watched Priya since her sub-junior days in 2018. To her, Priya's rise is a story of training through scarcity and competing through anxiety.

"I have been seeing Priya since her sub-junior competitions in 2018. One of the biggest challenges we have faced is that we do not have proper equipment in Manipur," Lakshmi Devi said. "But she always wanted to win medals for the country, which she achieved at the Asian Rowing Cup this year."

"There are just two centres in Manipur. One is in Bishnupur district and another is in Imphal. There is just one single sculls boat, one double sculls boat and one fours boat, and they are old," Priya said. "Here at IIS, the facilities are really good. We have multiple new boats, and even when we are on the water, we are monitored. The data is later studied by the coaches so that we can improve."

During the Hangzhou Games, the violence in Manipur had reached areas close to home. Lakshmi Devi recalls how difficult it was for Priya to separate racing from the fear that arrived with every phone call from her family. "Priya's house was just kilometres away from where the



Riding the high wave: Diljot Kaur and Suman Devi won bronze at the Asian Rowing Cup in South Korea earlier this year, clocking 8:02.384 and earning qualification for the Asian Games.

violence was happening. There was a full lockdown when the Hangzhou Asian Games was taking place," Lakshmi Devi said. "We were in the India camp, so we were lucky in one way. But whenever a call came from home, she would get nervous. That affected her performance at the Asian Games as well."

This context gives Priya's 2026 qualification a different weight.

In Chungju, Priya and Poonam finished second in the heats, which boosted their confidence ahead of the final.

Need to adapt

"It was an important victory for us. We finished second in the heats and then we were confident about winning a medal," Priya said. "On the day of the final, our coaches motivated us and we won bronze."

Priya's recent training indicators have also raised expectations. In training, she has touched the 7:22 mark, a sign that the double sculls

boat has room to improve.

That remains the challenge for all rowers. Training water is not race water. Wind changes, lanes differ and pressure tightens the hands. For India's women rowers, the next few months will be about sustaining that promise under continental pressure.

At IIS, the work continues away from the spotlight. Boats head out in the morning, coaches study the sessions, nutrition plans are adjusted and recovery is monitored.

For Indian rowing, the facility in Vijayanagar is an attempt to provide women rowers not just with boats and water, but with a system. At IIS, the work continues in quiet repetition: Diljot and Suman in the coxless pair, Priya and Poonam in the double sculls — two boats trying to push Indian women's rowing into a faster current before Aichi-Nagoya.

As the session ends, the water returns to stillness. By then, it has carried a small part of India's Asian Games hopes.

